

TEST PROCESS

To test the multimedia authoring software, we imported two bitmaps (24 bits), one JPEG, one TIFF, and an animated GIF and added text (anti-aliased and approximately 200 words) and checked if we could format text and whether the text was saved in graphic format or in text format itself. We then used features (transition, animation, etc) as available in a software to animate pictures and apply effects. We created an entire multimedia

project and even tried saving it as an executable that can be opened and played without having to install the actual software. We also looked for features such as ease of use, file formats supported, transition effects available, animation effects that could be done from within the software itself, buttons and mouse-over effects, and drawing tools available. We also looked at the level of help offered by the software.

Among the packages themselves, Macromedia has been coming up with new versions of its main package, Director, for quite some time and also has Authorware, which is more focussed on the creation of educational packages. At the same time, multimedia is not restricted to a single medium. For instance, Macromedia is trying to integrate Flash, used largely for Web-based animation into Authorware for creating timelines. Hence, we also tested Web-based multimedia creation tools such as Flash and Adobe LiveMotion.

Features

A good feature-set is essential in a multimedia authoring tool if you are looking to create dazzling CD-titles or multimedia projects.

File formats supported:

The wider the variety of file formats that can be imported into a software, the wider is the scope of working with different types of objects, say images, sounds or video files. Here, we saw that Formula Graphic 97 did not support importing images saved in the TIFF format and, like Adobe LiveMotion and Illuminatus Opus, it could not import MP3 audio files either. Having to import Wav sound files implies increased file sizes and it also consumes unnecessarily more memory. With MP3 having become such a universally accepted standard, the inability to support these files is a rather glaring absence.

Except Director 8.5 and Formula Graphic 97, none had the facility of importing 3D objects. With this feature, 3D files created in 3D Studio can be read and worked on directly within the software.

Macromedia's Flash supports importing

MOV and AVI files. However, when one imports AVI, it takes it in as a sequence of bitmaps and not as a single file. On the other hand, Adobe's LiveMotion does not support importing of video files at all, which is not a big deal if you consider the bandwidth restrictions on the Web.

Animation and transition effects: Multimedia titles rely a lot on animation and transition effects. Authorware does not have any facility for creating animations but it can import Flash animations. Formula Graphic 97 only features five predefined ways of animating objects and hence, custom animation can't be done. Whereas Illuminatus Opus does allow you to have custom animation, it does not support masking, a feature available in Adobe LiveMotion and Macromedia's Flash.

Authorware, Flash and LiveMotion have absolutely no predefined set of transitions. However, with the help of scripting you can create transitions but it is quite a tough task. Instead, you would prefer to use a software such as Director or Illuminatus Opus that provides an extensive list of predefined transitions that can easily be added.

Buttons: The facility to add buttons helps in adding dynamic elements to the page and also helps in enhancing navigation. Here, all the software were able to create buttons, but Flash and LiveMotion provided an excellent library of colourful buttons where all you had to do was

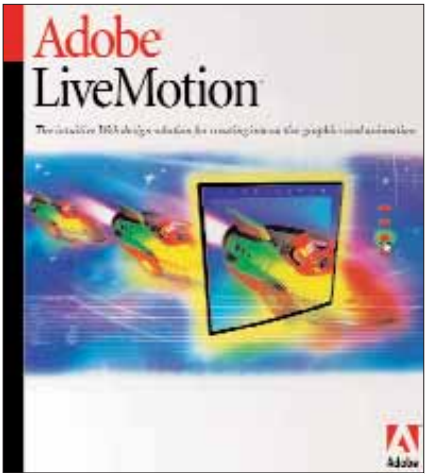
drag and drop them on to the stage. Assigning actions to these buttons was also easy—with just a click you could choose from a predefined set of actions.

Drawing tools: Last-minute alterations to or addition of drawing elements to the project becomes easier if the software integrates drawing capabilities into its functionality. All the software provided this feature but there were variations in the degree to which this functionality was implemented. Flash and Adobe LiveMo-

tion provide the pen tool for more accuracy in drawing objects, thus eliminating the need to work with a separate drawing application.

Projector creation: A multimedia project should be able to run in all the machines without requiring the software to be installed, and should have no problems in rendering fonts either. For this, the software should allow you to create a project.

Authorware, LiveMotion and Formula Graphic 97 did not possess this feature. You could only view projects created through these applications if the application itself was installed



Adobe LiveMotion has a good set of filters



More Info on the test process and the products tested,
Software related to sound editing, check out
Mindware

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